

Intersecting Inequalities in the U.S. Labor Market

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RESEARCH QUESTION

How do citizenship status and sex jointly shape wage disparities in the U.S. labor market?

Background

- The U.S. foreign-born population hit a record **53.3 million (15.8%)** in 2025. Immigrants are economically indispensable, yet persistently undercompensated.
- The **intersection of citizenship and gender** in wage-setting is understudied. Prior work treats immigrants as a uniform group.

Data & Sample

- American Community Survey**, pooled 2012–2019.
- 5% cluster sample of PUMA–state geographies: N = 526,832 workers across 118 geographies; wages in 2015 USD.
- Mean Annual Wages: men \$62,537 vs. women \$41,441; non-citizen women earn just 66% of non-citizen men.

Income by Group

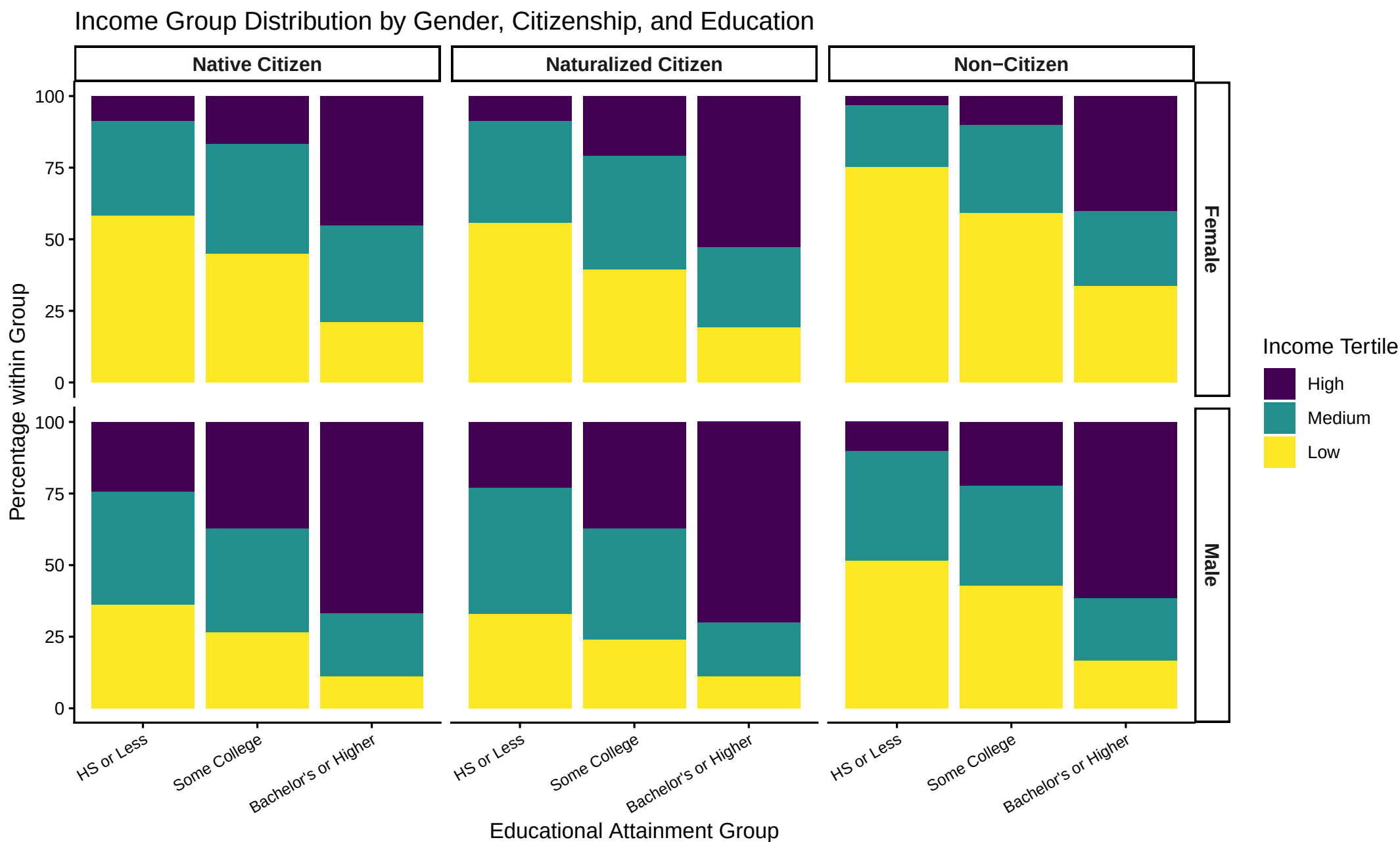


Fig 1. Even among bachelor's-degree holders, non-citizen women stay concentrated in the low-income bracket.

Empirical Strategy

- Modified **Mincer** log-wage regression with human-capital and race controls and fixed effects for year, industry, birthplace, and PUMA–state.
- Two-fold **Blinder–Oaxaca** decomposition splits each gap into **characteristics** (explained) vs. **returns** (unexplained).

$$\ln(wage_{ist}) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Nat + \beta_2 NonCit + \beta_3 Female + \beta_4 (Nat \times Female) + \beta_5 (NonCit \times Female) + \mathbf{Z}'\gamma + FE + \varepsilon_{ist}$$

$\mathbf{Z}$ is a vector of controls (education, English proficiency, age, children, race); FE = year, industry, birthplace & geography fixed effects. β_5 (highlighted) is the parameter of interest: the extra penalty on non-citizen women beyond gender and citizenship alone.

Regression Results

Table 1. Gender & Citizenship on Log Wages

	M1	M2	M3
Naturalized Citizen	0.148***	0.042***	0.045**
Non-Citizen	−0.247***	−0.018	−0.020
Female	−0.403***	−0.437***	−0.359***
Nat × Female	0.019	0.043**	0.023
NonCit × Female	−0.040**	−0.042***	−0.048***
Controls		✓	✓
Fixed effects			✓
R ²	0.038	0.339	0.390

N = 526,832.

***p < .01, **p < .05, *p < .1

⇒ The interaction β_5 stays **negative and significant across all three models**. The intersectional penalty on non-citizen women is robust.

−30%
women's wage gap

+4.6%
naturalization premium

−4.7%
extra penalty on
non-citizen women**

Decomposition

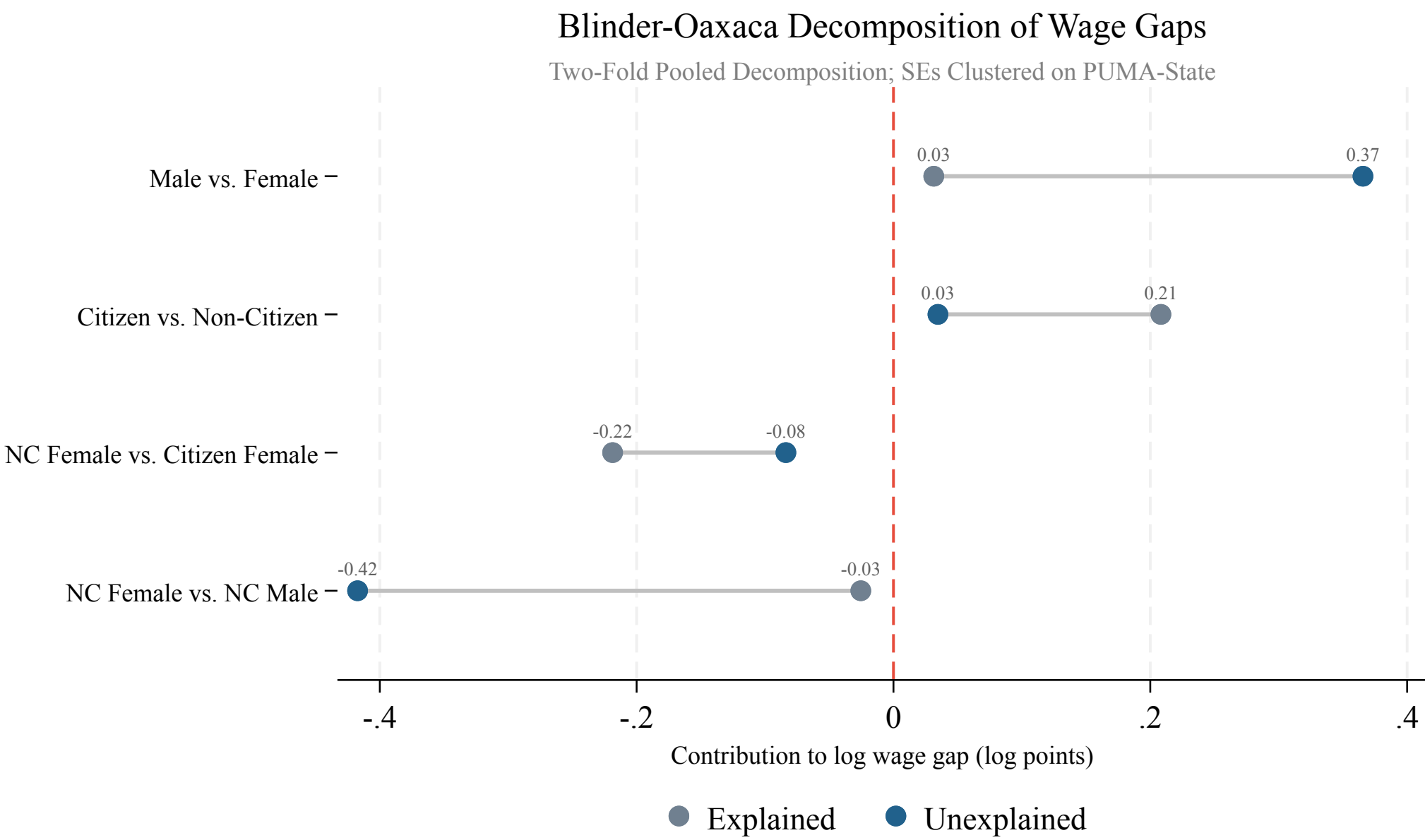


Fig 3. Explained (characteristics) vs. unexplained (returns) shares, four contrasts.

What Drives Each Gap?

- Gender gap: 92% unexplained.** The disparity reflects unequal returns rather than differences in qualifications.
- Citizenship gap: 86% explained** by English and education, not unequal pay.
- Non-citizen women vs. men: 94% unexplained.** This unexplained share exceeds that of the overall gender wage gap.

Conclusion

- Citizenship gaps are largely **structural** (human capital); gender gaps are largely **unexplained** (discrimination).
- Non-citizen women face a **compounded, intersectional penalty** that survives the full fixed-effects battery.
- Policy must target discrimination directly.

Selected References

Blinder (1973) · Oaxaca (1973) · Browne & Misra (2003) · Coulombe et al. (2014) · Donahue (2021). Data: IPUMS ACS, Ruggles et al. (2025).



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